When Life Moves Online: Digital Life and Fertility Trends in the United States

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Abstract

As digital technologies become more deeply integrated into everyday life, they may shape fertility through competing channels. On one hand, digital activities can displace face-to-face interaction, offline leisure and family time. On the other hand, digital technologies can increase flexible work arrangements, reduce information costs and ease coordinating family life. *Does greater digital life correspond to higher or lower fertility trends, and for whom?* I construct a state-year Digital Life Index for the United States that captures three dimensions of digitalization: remote work, digital leisure, and access to internet services. A one-standard-deviation increase in the lagged index is associated with approximately 2.1 fewer births per 1,000 women ages 30–39 years. The estimates for women in their twenties and forties are statistically insignificant. This negative relationship is more pronounced among married women living with their spouses, women in occupations with higher potential for remote work, and women with postsecondary education less than bachelor's degree. Spouse's occupation also plays an important role: the relationship goes in opposite direction depending on whether husbands are in jobs with high potential for remote work or jobs that require face-to-face interaction. The findings suggest that digital life has a negative relationship with fertility trends, but this relationship is heterogeneous by work and family circumstances.

1 Introduction

In advanced economies, birth rates have declined to historically low levels in recent years. Total fertility rates are now below the replacement rate in all high-income countries. Since 2007 the fertility rates started declining in the United States (Figure 1). By 2024 fertility rate has reached a record low at 1.6 births per woman (Osterman et al., 2026). Such low fertility rates has far-reaching socioeconomic implications on aging population, demographic dividend, labor force composition, economic growth and safety net programs (Crespo Cuaresma et al., 2013; Danzer & Zyska, 2023; Lee & Mason, 2009; Maestas et al., 2023; Margolis & Myrskylä, 2015; Myrskylä et al., 2025; Timæus & Moultrie, 2020).

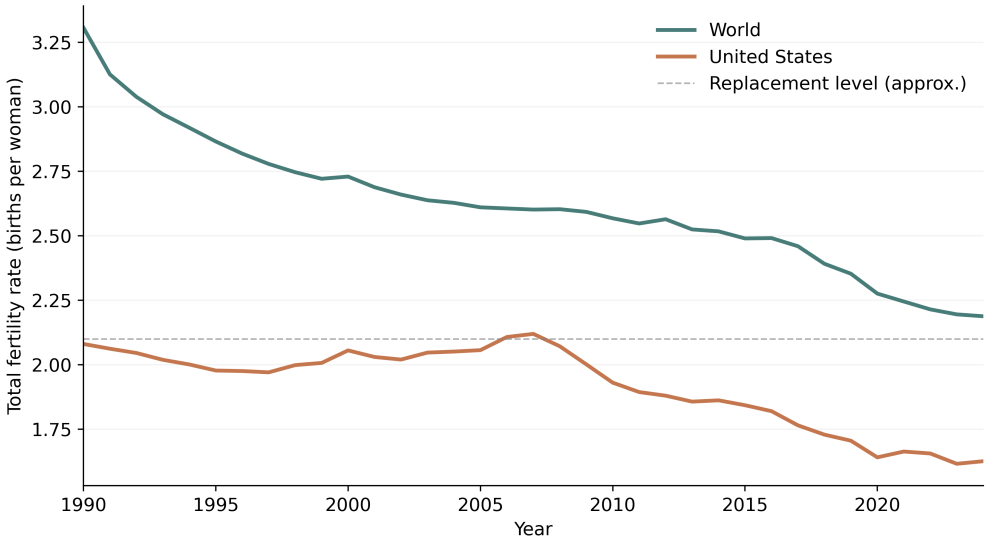


Figure 1: *Fertility Trends in the United States and the World (1990-2024). It presents annual total fertility rates (births per woman) of the United States and the World. The dashed horizontal line is the replacement fertility rate of 2.1 births per woman. Source: World Bank, World Development Indicators.*

According to the demographic transition model, development raises the cost of having more children as urbanization, education and access to birth control generate life goals which conflict with fertility (Becker, 1960; Birdsall, 1988; Coale, 1973; Notestein, 1945; Willis, 1973). This suggests a negative association between fertility and economic development. However, this model was challenged by Myrskylä et al. (2009) who found an inverse J-shaped relationship: fertility declines at low and medium levels of economic development but rises when the development is sufficiently high. Recent evidence from the United States again challenges this narrative. Schubert et al. (2024) report that the positive association disappeared after the Great Recession in 2007-08 and the relationship became an inverted U-shape during 1995-2018.

Existing literature on the determinants of fertility has emphasized household income, women's education and career opportunities, human capital investment and coordinating family-work

life (Adda et al., 2017; Becker, 1960; Cesarini et al., 2023; Doepke et al., 2023; Goldin, 2021; Jones et al., 2011; Kearney & Levine, 2026; Lovenheim & Mumford, 2013; Myrskylä et al., 2025). Recently, there has been growing interest toward whether remote work can reduce work-family trade-off and improve childbearing. But emerging evidence is mixed. While Davis et al. (2026) show a positive association between remote working and fertility outcomes, recent study by Johnston (2026) finds that a one-standard-deviation increase in teleworkability reduced annual birth rates by 2 percent among married women. These contradictory results show that flexibility alone is not driving the relationship between remote work and flexibility. While remote jobs can save commuting time, it does not necessarily reduce workload. Moreover, greater exposure to digital devices and social media often reduce time for competing offline activities such as socializing with family and friends (Aguiar et al., 2021; Allcott et al., 2020). These suggest that digital technologies can influence relative attractiveness of time use toward other activities which can potentially impact decisions about childbearing and family formation. But the nature of the relationship between exposure to digital technologies and fertility outcomes remains an empirical question.

In this paper, I examine whether and to what extent digital exposure is associated with fertility outcomes in the United States. More specifically, I construct state-year varying digital life index (DLI) that covers three dimensions: the prevalence of working from home, intensity of leisure activities using digital devices and household access to high-speed internet and cellular data plan. Linking these state-year measures to women's birth outcomes from Current Population Survey, I estimate the association between lagged digital life index and birth outcomes, separately for any birth, first birth and higher-order birth among women aged 15-49 years. To estimate these, I use a linear probability model with two-way fixed effects, namely individual-level and conception-period fixed effects. Because the extent to which a state is digitalized depends on its economic activities, I control for state-level economic growth over the same period as the DLI is included in the empirical specification. I also account for pre-existing general fertility rate[1] which is likely to confound the relationship between digital life and fertility.

The results reveal substantial differences across various reproductive age groups. A one-standard-deviation (1-SD) increase in lagged DLI is associated with 2.16 fewer any birth per 1,000 women aged 30-39 years. Upon further looking into order of births, I find that a 1-SD increase in lagged DLI is associated with 0.74 fewer first birth per 1,000 women aged 15-19 years and 2.07 higher-order births per 1,000 women in their thirties. But the associations for women in their twenties and forties are statistically insignificant. The pattern also differs by marital status, occupation and advanced education, particularly among women aged 30-39 years. For married women living with their spouses, a 1-SD increase in lagged DLI is associated with 3.8 fewer births per 1,000 women in their thirties. The negative association is also apparent among women in remote-compatible occupation and with postsecondary education less than bachelor's degree. Spouse's occupation also plays an important role: among women

[1] that is, number of live births per woman

with spouses in remote-compatible jobs, a 1-SD increase in lagged DLI is associated 5.6 fewer births per 1,000 women aged 30-39 years. On the contrary, the relationship becomes positive among women in their twenties if their spouses are in occupations which require face-to-face interactions.

This paper contributes to two strands of the literature. Firstly, this paper contributes to the literature on the determinants of fertility in high-income countries. Existing studies on factors related to fertility outcomes, have emphasized the roles of economic development, growing women's employment, high household-level income, trade-off between quality and quantity of children and balancing career-family life (Doepke et al., 2023; Goldin, 2021; Myrskylä et al., 2009, 2025; Schubert et al., 2024). I extend this literature by bringing the role of digitalization on fertility trends in the United States across different reproductive age groups.

Secondly, this paper also contributes to the growing role of digital technology and fertility by introducing a broader measure of digitalization which not only includes remote work but also leisure and accessibility to digital devices and services. Growing studies have focused on how access to broadband and remote work arrangements share negative relationship with fertility outcomes. Myers and Hooper (2026) shows that the rollout of the iphone reduced adolescent births by 4.5–8.0% and 3.2–6.6% among women in their early twenties. S. Wang and Dong (2024)find that women in flexible work arrangements are more likely to report high intended fertility in Singapore. Lu et al. (2026) shows that women in teleworkable occupations are approximately 1.2 percentage points more likely to have first births in their thirties. I contribute to this literature by constructing a composite digital life measurement and estimate the association between digitalization and birth events in the United States.

2 Conceptual Framework

Theoretically, the relationship between digitalization and fertility can go in both directions. On one hand, digital technologies provide more information access to prospective parents. On the other hand, digital technologies also give more opportunities for entertainment activities that compete for individual's time and attention. Conventional economic models of fertility have emphasized on the role of family income, opportunity cost of women's time toward paid employment, cost of childrearing and quality-quantity trade-off as the main drivers. Kearney and Levine (2026) argue that these models assume static preferences and augment the standard model with evolving social norms. As our lives are getting more digitalized, this can influence gendered norms and thereby, the nexus between digital life and fertility. I discuss how three key dimensions of digitalization, specifically, remote work, digital leisure and digital accessibility are related with fertility and can vary with reproductive age and family circumstances.

2.1 Remote work, Employment and Family Life

Existing literature on remote work argue that remote work is beneficial for women's career by improving flexibility through reducing commuting costs and improving coordination between work, childcare and other unpaid household responsibilities (Angelici & Profeta, 2024; Bloom et al., 2024; Mas & Pallais, 2017; Osterman et al., 2026). These changes could reduce opportunity cost of having children through the flexibility channel (S. Wang & Dong, 2024).Lu et al. (2026) shows that women in thirties are more likely to have first births if they are in remote jobs. Davis et al. (2026) report positive association between working remotely and fertility. But workplace flexibility does not necessarily increase more time for families by reducing working hours. If remote jobs increase value of professional opportunities, it could raise cost of childcare from additional children. Johnston (2026) show that growing exposure to remote work reduces birth rates, especially among married working women in the United States. Hence, it is not sufficient to say that the prevalence of remote work is equivalent with increased time for parenting. Therefore, the net sign of the relationship between remote or digital work and fertility is indeterminate.

2.2 Digital Leisure and Alternatives to Parenthood

Digital technologies have also expanded the set of activities outside paid employment. Online entertainment such as social media, and infinite-browsing can provide enjoyment and information other than in-person interactions. Because time is fixed, these activities also compete for other uses of time. Whether these encourage or discourage childbearing depends on how digital activities substitute or complement family-related activities including childbearing and parenthood. Allcott et al. (2020) show that deactivating Facebook reduced online activities and increased socializing with family and friends. But at the same time, this same activity increased offline activities such as watching TV alone—which again is another digital leisure activity. Aguiar et al. (2021) show that digital recreation using computer lowered young men's working hours by 2 percent. In this context, digital leisure is likely to have negative association with fertility.

2.3 Digital Infrastructure and Birth trends

Access to internet and cellular data are fundamental for remote work arrangements, digital leisure and any other activity that requires digital devices. Better connectivity enables flexible jobs, reduces cost of information and job search frictions, as well as other online resources. Therefore, the relationship between digital infrastructure and birth trends is indeterminate. On one hand, it can reduce the barriers to work and family life. For example, Billari et al. (2019) show that broadband accessibility increases fertility among highly educated women in Germany by increasing more access to part-time work opportunities which reduces cost of childcare. But digital access is also a prerequisite to digital leisure and the latter is more likely to absorb individual's time from other competing activities including social media, video games and browsing. Myers and Hooper (2026) shows that access to digital technol-

ogy, namely iphone actually reduced birth rates among young adults. This implies that the relationship between digital accessibility and fertility may not be monotonically positive. It should be noted that digital accessibility is different than actual digital activity. A typical household can have internet access without engaging in remote work or online social media and games and vary across income, education, occupation and family structure. The digital accessibility works as an enabling option for digital activities.

2.4 Hypotheses

The preceding discussions leads to the following testable hypotheses:

Hypothesis 1: Digital life is associated with fertility but the direction of the impact is theoretically indeterminate.

Hypothesis 2: The relationship between digital life and fertility differs across various age groups and also by the order of birth-first and higher order birth outcomes.

Hypothesis 3: The relationship should be heterogeneous across women depending on their work and family circumstances, particularly, nature of occupation, marital status and spouses' work status.

Next, we move to data and empirical analyses to estimate the nature of the relationship between digital life and fertility outcomes.

3 Data and Measurement

I combine individual-level data from Current Population Survey (CPS) data with state-year varying measurement constructed using data from American Community Survey (ACS) and American Time Use Survey (ATUS). CPS provides panel data using a 4-8-4 pattern over a 16-month period whereby households are interviewed consecutively for four months, take break for eight months and are again interviewed for next four months. ACS and ATUS report state-representative data on various aspects of digital life including remote work, digital access and time use on leisure activities. I use these information to generate a composite digital life index which varies across state over time[2].

3.1 Data Sources

Current Population Survey (CPS). This is a nationally representative survey which is jointly conducted by the Bureau of Labor Statistics and the Census Bureau. It provides longitudinal records using a 4-8-4 pattern over a 16-month period whereby households are interviewed consecutively for four months, take break for eight months and are again interviewed for next four months. The rotating panel design allows us to match respondents

[2]Since ATUS is representative at the state level but not at MSA, CBSA or county level, I use the states as geographic sources of variation, despite that the ACS provides representative sample at the MSA level.

across survey months which helps us to construct fertility histories and include individual fixed effects. I restrict the analytical sample to women aged 15-49 years. I primarily use information on women's fertility, age, marital status, own education, own and spouse's occupation, state and year.

American Time Use Survey. This survey tracks time spent by individuals across various activities. Using phone interviews, the U.S. Census Bureau collects 24-hour time diaries from nationally representative sample of U.S. residents and records how respondents allocate their time across different activities including paid labor, household production, leisure and other activities. ATUS splits free-time and leisure activities across two major categories, namely (i) Socializing, Relaxing and Leisure and (ii) Sports, Exercise and Recreation. I focus only on leisure and recreation activities which require digital devices.

American Community Survey. This is a repeated cross-sectional survey which is conducted by the U.S. Census Bureau and cover approximately 3.5 million households every year. It provides detailed information on demographic, social and economic characteristics across the United States. For this analysis, I leverage the microdata from seven rounds during 2016-2023 and extract shares of remote working population in each state over time.

3.2 Measures

3.2.1 Fertility Outcomes

I construct three fertility variables by leveraging the longitudinal format of monthly CPS data: any birth, first birth and higher-order birth. Since CPS follows a 4-8-4 pattern, it helps to link women across repeated monthly interviews by validating longitudinal identifier. I identify a birth event when the number of own children residing in a household increases between two consecutive CPS interviews and the youngest child in the current month is younger than one year.

More specifically, I define *any birth* dummy that takes value one if a birth event takes place between two adjacent monthly interviews and zero otherwise. I differentiate first birth from higher-order birth using number of own children in a household. I define *first birth* dummy if a birth event is observed between two adjacent monthly interviews and had no own child in their household during the previous interview. By similar logic, I define *higher-order birth* dummy if a birth event takes place between two adjacent monthly interviews and had at least one own child in the household from the last interview.

Following Kreyenfeld et al. (2023), births are backdated by nine months to approximate conception timing, and the objective is to map the fertility-decision making with the time trends, digital life metric and time-varying state characteristics. Since the CPS does not report the exact birth dates, the backdating approach based on youngest child's age can generate measurement error. In 2022, preterm births accounted for nearly 10% of all live

births in the U.S. in which gestational period differs from the usual nine-month period (Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, 2024). Moreover, reported age in each household roster is measured in completed years which can lead to minor temporal misalignment around monthly boundaries. However, these measurement errors are unlikely to bias the estimates because these are not directly related with the lagged state-year varying digital life index.

3.2.2 Construction of Digital Life Index

To capture digital life, I construct state-year varying digital life index (DLI) which captures three dimensions: digital work, digital leisure and digital accessibility. The objective of constructing this index is to capture broader digital environment in the geographical areas where individuals live. This is because digitalization can influence fertility trends through competing channels. While remote work and access to high speed internet can reduce commuting cost and ease coordinating between work and household responsibilities (Aksoy et al., 2023; Barrero et al., 2021). This can positively influence fertility outcomes (Davis et al., 2026). On the contrary, better internet accessibility and greater time spent on digital devices for leisure or work can reduce in-person socializing. This, in turn, can negatively impact fertility outcomes. Recently, Johnston (2026) showed that teleworkability reduced annual births by 2% after the COVID-19 pandemic hit.

Using information from ACS and ATUS during 2016-2023, I first aggregate individual-level and household-level data to time-varying state-level measures. Then, I standardize each component measure and define the digital life index as:

$$\text{Digital Life Index}_{st} = \frac{z_{st}^{\text{Digital Work}} + z_{st}^{\text{Digital Leisure}} + z_{st}^{\text{Digital Access}}}{3} \tag{1}$$

where $z_{st}^{(.)}$ is the z-score of each component so that the mean becomes zero and standard deviation becomes one. *Digital work* refers to the shares of individuals aged 16 years and above who work remotely in each state s and year t. This captures the time-varying prevalence of remote work in each state which heavily depend on digital devices and internet accessibility. *Digital leisure* combines both the time spent on digital devices for leisure or recreation and the share of population engaged in these leisure activities. This reflects to what extent people are engaged with digital devices outside their daily jobs. *Digital accessibility* refers to the shares of households with internet access, cellular data plan and high-speed broadband. This component shows the status of digital infrastructure in each state s during year t. More details can be found in Digital Life Index website.



Figure 2: Digital Life Index Across U.S. States in 2019 and 2022.

Notes: The maps show geographic distribution of the digital life index (DLI) across U.S. states in 2019 (left panel) and 2022 (right panel). The index is standardized so that the mean and standard deviation is 0 and 1 respectively. Darker shades indicate higher values of DLI. Darker shades indicate higher values of DLI. *Sources:* Author's compilation using American Community Survey and American Time Use Survey; author's calculations.

3.2.3 Covariates and Subgroup Characteristics

I include individual's age to control for changes in fertility over reproductive life courses. To account for other time-invariant individual-level characteristics, I include the CPS longitudinal identifier (CPSIDV) which identifies individuals across monthly CPS interviews. At the state level, I also include two time-varying factors:
(i) Economic growth: It is measured as change in real GDP from year $t-1$ to t and the data is captured from U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC)
(ii) General fertility rate (GFR): It is defined as the number of live births per 1,000 women in the childbearing age. This data is obtained from U.S. Bureau of Economic Analysis.

I classify women into four age groups (15-19, 20-29, 30-39, 40-49 years) to separately analyze variation in fertility outcomes across adolescence, young adulthood, thirties and forties. I further examine stratified heterogeneous effects based on marital status, advanced educational attainment and occupational characteristics. I categorize marital status into three main groups: married with spouses present, married with spouses absent, and unmarried. By advanced education, I mean postsecondary education in which I generate two groups: some postsecondary education but less than bachelor's degree and those with bachelor's degree and above.

In the context of occupational characteristics, I focus on whether an occupation can be performed remotely or require face-to-face interaction since remote working is highly correlated with realized fertility and lifetime fertility (Davis et al., 2026). I utilize the remote work and face-to-face scores developed by Montenovo et al. (2022). Using the 2019 O*NET work

context survey, they scored each question on a 1-5 scale and used the simple average of scores of relevant question to construct remote work and face-to-face indices. The remote work index was constructed using task survey questions on use of electronic mail, written letters, and phone conversation while the face-to-face index was designed using questions on physical proximity and face-to-face discussions (Montenovo et al., 2022). I use occupation-level remote work and face-to-face interaction scores developed by Montenovo et al. (2022). Drawing on the 2019 O*NET work context survey, they construct each index as the simple average of scores on 1-5 scale for each relevant question. The remote-work index combines three measures capturing the frequency of electronic mail use, written correspondence, and telephone conversations, while the face-to-face index combines two measures capturing physical proximity to others and the frequency of face-to-face discussions (Montenovo et al., 2022). I use this remote vs face-to-face indices because of two reasons: firstly, these indices are constructed using pre-pandemic occupational characteristics which avoid changes in work innovation induced by the COVID-19 pandemic; second, the indices can be readily harmonized with the 2010 Census occupational classification used in the CPS data.

3.3 Summary Statistics

Table 1 presents the summary statistics for the main sample variables. On average, the monthly birth incidence is 3.6 per 1,000 women. The corresponding average monthly first-order birth incidence is 2.7 per 1,000 women and higher-order birth incidence is 4.7 per 1,000 women. In panel B, the mean digital life index is 0.438. Average shares of women working remotely is 9.2%. Approximately, 78.5% of individuals do leisure activities using digital devices such as computer, television and average time spent on digital leisure is 156 minutes/day. Access to internet service is quite high: Nealry 82% of households have high-speed broadband internet while about 89% have cellular data plans. In terms of state-level aggregates, the mean GFR is 59 births per 1,000 women, and the annual economic growth rate is 2.3%.

4 Empirical Strategy

I estimate the relationship between digital life index and fertility using a two-way fixed effects model. The main specification is:

$$Y_{ist} = \beta \text{DLI}_{s,y(t-9)-1} + \mu \text{Age}_{ist} + \mathbf{X}'_{s,y(t-9)-1}\gamma + \tau_i + \lambda_{t-9} + \epsilon_{ist} \tag{2}$$

where Y_{ist} denotes fertility outcome of woman i in state s and observed in month t. I estimate the above equation (2) separately using three fertility outcome variables, namely (i) any birth, (ii) first birth and (iii) higher-order birth across reproductive age groups (15-19 years to 40-49 years).

The main independent variable, $\text{DLI}_{s,y(t-9)-1}$, is the digital life index (DLI) in state s during one calendar year prior the conception-year. A birth observed during an interview month

t implies that the fertility decision is made approximately 9 months earlier. So, I define $t-9$ as the conception-month and $y(t-9)$ as the corresponding calendar year. Because the measure of digital environment is also contemporaneously determined by the fertility outcome, I use the lagged DLI observed in year$y(t-9)-1$ to reduce the potential reverse causality. β is the coefficient of interest. Conditional on individual and time fixed effects, it measures the change in the probability of a birth outcome associated with a 1-SD increase in lagged digital life.

Table 1: Summary Statistics

Variable	Mean	SD	N
A. Individual-level variables			
Any birth	0.0036	0.0598	1,550,918
First birth	0.0027	0.0516	857,468
Higher-order birth	0.0047	0.0686	693,450
Age	29.932	8.613	2,353,129
B. State-level digital measures			
Digital Life Index	0.438	0.163	357
Remote work share	0.092	0.058	357
Share with any digital leisure	0.785	0.081	357
Mean digital leisure minutes	156.24	33.617	357
Internet access share	0.896	0.045	357
High-speed broadband share	0.819	0.046	357
Cellular data plan share	0.891	0.048	357
C. State-level demographic and economic measures			
General fertility rate	59.101	5.980	357
Real GDP growth	2.293	2.678	357

Notes: Panel (A) uses CPS data during 2017-2023 and the sample is restricted to women aged 15-49 years. Panel (B) reports state-level digital measures which are constructed using ACS and ATUS data during 2016-2023. Panel (C) depicts demographic and economic measures for each state and year using CDC and State GDP from U.S. Bureau of Economic Analysis. I have excluded 2020 from the sample because the ATUS did not provide a comparable full-year estimate for that year.

$\mathbf{X}_{s,y(t-9)-1}$ is vector of time-varying state-level characteristics which can potentially influence the relationship between digital life and fertility outcomes. More specifically, I control for lagged economic growth and general fertility rate (GFR) to match with timing of DLI used in the Eq (2). Economic conditions are significant confounder since fertility responds to fluctuations in local macroeconomic conditions. Previous studies show that fertility trends decline during economic downturns while improvements in local income and economic activities are positively correlated with higher birth rates (Buckles et al., 2021; Currie & Schwandt, 2014; Schaller et al., 2020; Schneider, 2015). I include GFR as another control to account for pre-existing state-level demographic conditions which can influence the relationship between digital life and birth outcomes. Lagged fertility measures are often used in dynamic specification to control for recent fertility history (Bailey, 2012; Schneider, 2015; Y. Wang et al.,

2022). This is important because states with different fertility trajectories are likely to differ in how digital life is associated with individual-level fertility behavior.

I additionally control for age (Age_{ist}) to absorb changes in fertility trends over reproductive ages. Other time-invariant individual socioeconomic and demographic characteristics are included in the individual fixed effects, τ_i. This mitigates bias arising from time-invariant differences across individuals. I also control for time fixed effects, λ_{t-9} to account for any common shock and seasonality during conception-period $t-9$. Standard errors, ϵ_{ist} are clustered at state-level to control for any within-state serial correlation over time.

5 Results

5.1 Digital Life and Fertility over the Reproductive Life Cycle

Figure (3) shows the results from estimating equation (2) which estimates the overall relationship between digital life and births among women aged 15-49 years. It reveals differential nature of association across age groups and birth order. In case of any birth outcome, the estimated relationship is statistically significant among women aged 30-39 years. A one-standard-deviation (1-SD) increase in digital life is associated with 2.16 fewer births per 1000 women. The estimated coefficients are negligible and statistically insignificant for the other age groups. For first births, the estimated relationship is concentrated among teen women in the age group of 15-19 years. A 1-SD increase in lagged digital life is associated with 0.74 fewer first births per 1000 women aged 15-19 years. The effect is insignificant across other age groups. In case of higher-order births, the negative relationship is most pronounced among women aged 30-39 years.

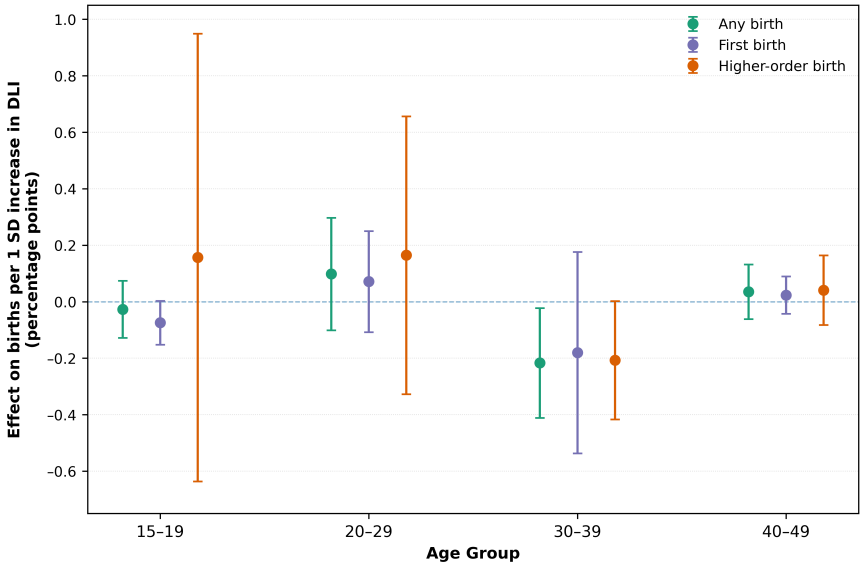


Figure 3: Association Between Digital Life and Birth Outcomes Across Reproductive Age Groups. *Notes:* The figure reports estimated coefficients and 95% confidence intervals for any birth, first birth, and higher-order birth among women aged 15–19, 20–29, 30–39, and 40–49 years. Estimates represent changes in monthly birth probability, expressed in percentage points. All specifications control for age, lagged state-level general fertility rates, and real GDP growth, and include individual and conception-month fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the state level. The horizontal dashed line indicates zero association.

A 1-SD increase in digital life is associated with approximately 2.07 births per 1000 women aged 30-39 years. The estimates are not significantly different from zero for other age groups. The 95% confidence interval is quite large for higher order birth among 15-19 years since it is rare to have second or higher order birth in this age group. These results indicate that the lagged digital life has a negative relationship with fertility outcomes over reproductive life cycle. The results are consistent with delayed entry into motherhood among teens and lower overall and higher-order births among women in their thirties. However, the fertility patterns are not significant among women in their twenties or forties.

5.2 Marriage, Work, and Education

The estimated association between digital life and fertility trends across various reproductive age groups mask important heterogeneity driven by women's socioeconomic contexts. Understanding this heterogeneity helps to identify the subgroups for whom digital life is strongly associated with birth outcomes. In this section, I report stratified heterogeneous effects by marital status, own and spouse's occupation and post-secondary education attained.

Role of Marital Status. Figure (4) shows that the estimated relationship between digital life and birth outcomes vary by marital status. I compare women who are married and living with their spouses, married with spouses absent and unmarried women. The clearest pattern

emerges among women aged 30-39 years. Among married women with spouses present, a 1-SD increase in lagged digital life index is associated with 3.8 fewer any births per 1000 women and 3.6 fewer higher-order births per 1000 women. The corresponding effects are negligible in case of first births. On the contrary, the estimates for married women with an absent spouse and unmarried women are statistically insignificant. These results suggest that the negative association between digital life and birth outcomes among women in their thirties is concentrated among married women whose spouses are present.

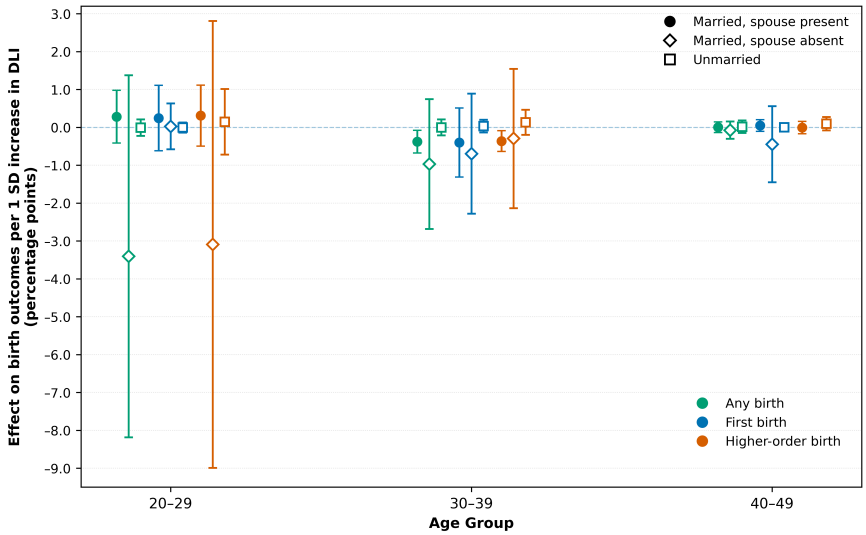


Figure 4: Association Between Digital Life and Birth Outcomes by Marital Status Across Reproductive Age Groups. *Notes:* The figure reports estimated coefficients and 95% confidence intervals for any birth, first birth, and higher-order birth among women aged 15–19, 20–29, 30–39, and 40–49 years. Estimates represent changes in monthly birth probability, expressed in percentage points. All specifications control for age, lagged state-level general fertility rates, and real GDP growth, and include individual and conception-month fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the state level. The horizontal dashed line indicates zero association.

Role of women's occupations. Figure (5) shows the subgroup analyses for women in occupations with high versus low potential for remote work. The substantial effects appear among women in their thirties and work in remote-compatible jobs. A 1-SD increase in lagged digital index is associated with nearly 2.2 fewer births per 1,000 women aged 30-39. But the estimates for first and higher-order birth outcomes are statistically insignificant. The results are negligible for women in their forties and imprecise for women aged 20-29 years. Thus, women's participation in remote-compatible jobs does not necessarily offset the negative relationship between digital life and fertility outcomes, particularly in their thirties when childbearing is relatively more common.

Role of Spouse's Occupations. Because family planning is usually a joint decision between a couple, it is important to explore how the relationship between digital life and fertility outcomes vary by spouse's occupations. In figure (6), I compare how the estimated

association differs across married women with spouses in remote-friendly jobs versus those with spouses in jobs that require face-to-face interaction. The negative relationship is concentrated among women in their thirties whose husbands are in remote-compatible jobs: a 1-SD increase in lagged digital life index is associated with 5.6 fewer any births per 1,000 women and 4.9 higher-order births per 1,000 women. Surprisingly, figure (6) shows a positive association among women in their twenties if their husbands are in jobs that require physical presence.

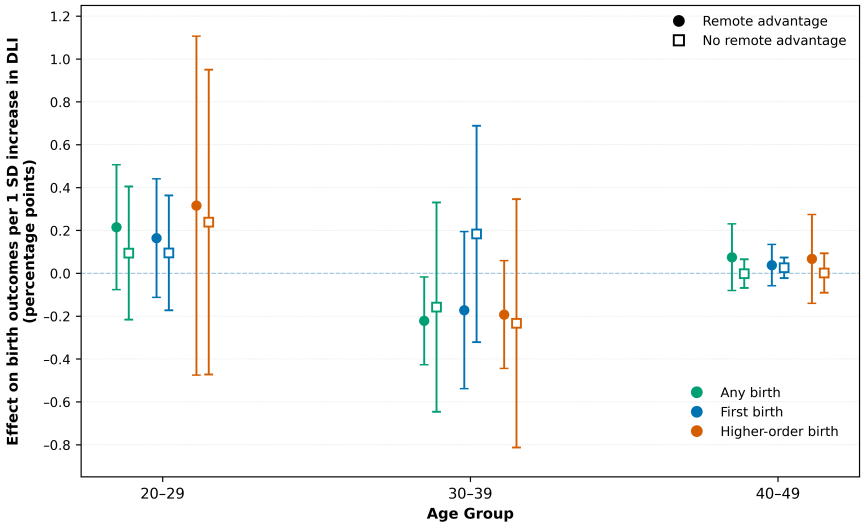


Figure 5: Association Between Digital Life and Birth Outcomes by Women's Remote Work Potential Across Reproductive Age Groups. *Notes:* The figure reports estimated coefficients and 95% confidence intervals for any birth, first birth, and higher-order birth among women aged 15–19, 20–29, 30–39, and 40–49 years. Following Montenovo et al. (2022), I use the pre-pandemic task classification to score an occupation's remote compatibility and face-to-face compatibility. Estimates represent changes in monthly birth probability, expressed in percentage points. All specifications control for age, lagged state-level general fertility rates, and real GDP growth, and include individual and conception-month fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the state level. The horizontal dashed line indicates zero association.

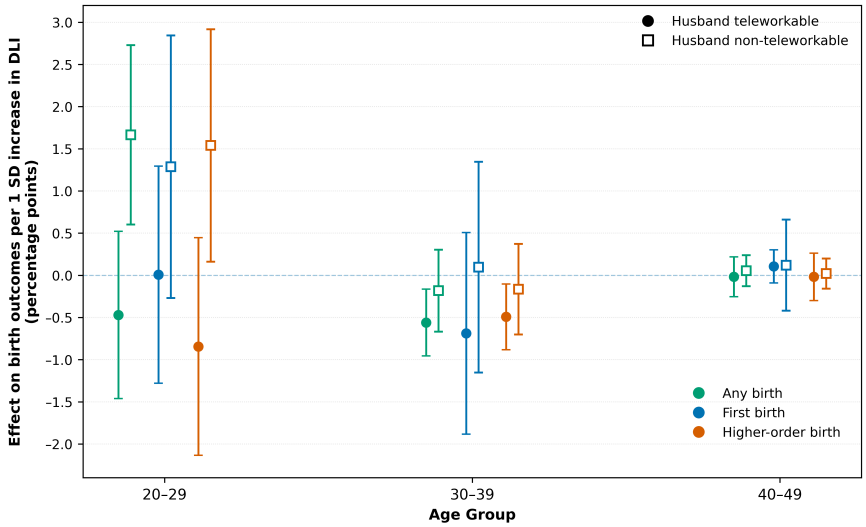


Figure 6: Association Between Digital Life and Birth Outcomes by Husband's Remote Work Potential Across Reproductive Age Groups. *Notes:* The figure reports estimated coefficients and 95% confidence intervals for any birth, first birth, and higher-order birth among women aged 15–19, 20–29, 30–39, and 40–49 years. Following Montenovo et al. (2022), I use the pre-pandemic task classification to score an occupation's remote compatibility and face-to-face compatibility. Estimates represent changes in monthly birth probability, expressed in percentage points. All specifications control for age, lagged state-level general fertility rates, and real GDP growth, and include individual and conception-month fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the state level. The horizontal dashed line indicates zero association.

Role of Post-Secondary Education. Figure (7) documents subgroup analyses by educational attainment. I compare women with some postsecondary education but less than bachelor's degree with women having bachelor's degree or higher. The significant heterogeneous effects emerge among women aged 30-39 years. Among women with less than bachelor's degree postsecondary education, a 1-SD increase in lagged digital life index is associated with approximately 5 fewer any births per 1,000 women which include 4.9 fewer first-order and 4.4 higher-order births per 1,000 women. However, the corresponding estimates for women who completed bachelor's degree or higher are statistically insignificant.

This pattern documents stark difference from the growing literature which highlights that the benefits of digital access and remote jobs are concentrated among highly educated women. A plausible reason behind this difference is that the digital life index is combination of different forms of digital exposure while previous studies focus solely on either individual-level remote work or digital access. Moreover, women with bachelor's degree and above are in better position to utilize digital technologies for flexible employment and better information access compared to women with less than bachelor's degree. As a result, they are less likely to get benefits from digital-enabled occupations and more likely to be exposed to broader changes in digital leisure and time use.

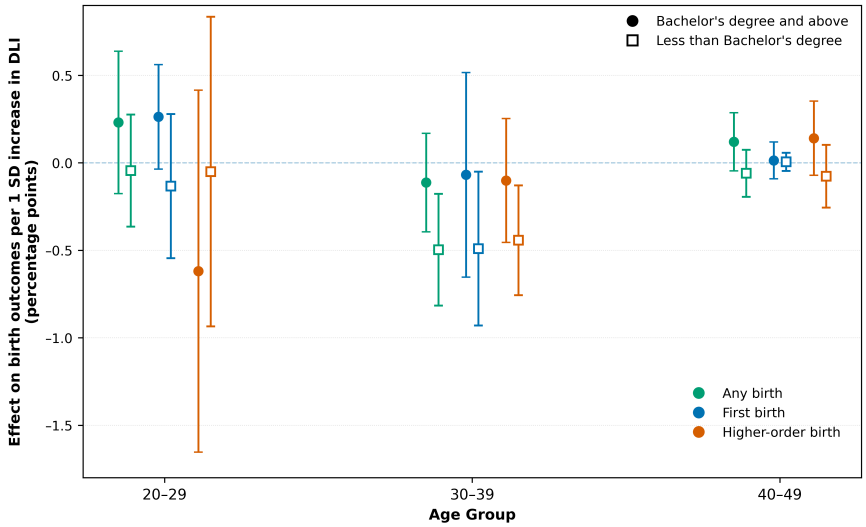


Figure 7: Association Between Digital Life and Birth Outcomes by Women's Post-Secondary Education Across Reproductive Age Groups. *Notes:* The figure reports estimated coefficients and 95% confidence intervals for any birth, first birth, and higher-order birth among women aged 15–19, 20–29, 30–39, and 40–49 years. Estimates represent changes in monthly birth probability, expressed in percentage points. All specifications control for age, lagged state-level general fertility rates, and real GDP growth, and include individual and conception-month fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the state level. The horizontal dashed line indicates zero association.

5.3 Supplemental Analyses

The main specification assumes a linear relationship between lagged DLI and fertility outcomes. Because the DLI is a combination of three different dimensions, namely, remote work, digital leisure and digital accessibility, the dimensions may not have a uniformly linear association with fertility. At low levels of digital exposure, improvements in connectivity can reduce information friction which can influence family bearing and birth outcomes. As digital exposure becomes more widespread, the benefits from additional digital access may decline while greater use of digital devices for leisure activities can raise the opportunity cost of offline social and family-related interactions. The latter can reduce birth outcomes. To assess the robustness of the findings, I include the squarred term for the lagged Digital Life Index in the main eq.(2) for examining the linearity assumption. The specification is as following:

$$Y_{ist} = \beta_1 \text{DLI}_{s,y(t-9)-1} + \beta_2 \text{DLI}^2_{s,y(t-9)-1} + \beta_3 \text{Age}_{ist} + \mathbf{X}'_{s,y(t-9)-1}\gamma + \tau_i + \lambda_{t-9} + \varepsilon_{ist} \quad (3)$$

Figure 8 shows the estimated relationship between fertility and lagged DLI. The results suggest limited evidence for nonlinearity. Among women in their thirties, the association between linear lagged DLI term and fertility remains negative while the estimated coefficient for the quadratic DLI is statistically insignificant. For higher-order births, the relationship between lagged DLI and fertility remains negative using both the linear and squared DLI

term. Importantly, figure 8 shows that the negative association becomes steeper at higher levels of lagged DLI. Similar results are observed among women aged 40-49 years (Figure 8). On the contrary, there exists a U-shaped relationship between lagged DLI and first birth among adolescent girls. While the teen births declines with rise in lagged DLI at low-to-medium levels, the relationship becomes positive at very high level of digitalization. The results are statistically insignificant among women in their twenties.

6 Conclusion

Since the Great Recession of 2007-08, fertility trends have declined substantially while the digital technologies have increasingly integrated in our daily lives. In this study I examine the relationship between digitalization and fertility in the United States. Previous studies have emphasized on the role of women's participation in paid labor and career opportunities in shaping fertility decisions. There has been a growing interest in whether digital work, particularly remote work can improve birth outcomes since it eliminates commuting and introduces flexibility to coordinate between work and personal responsibilities such as childcare. But evidence is mixed. One plausible reasons could be that digitalization also transforms leisure, social interaction, time allocation, and access to information and services. In this paper, I bring broad distinct dimensions of digital life, specifically, remote work, digital leisure and digital accessibility to estimate the nature of relationship between digital life and fertility in United States.

Using a newly constructed digital life index (DLI), I report a negative relationship between digital life and fertility, particularly among women in the age group 30-39 years. I show that a 1-SD increase in lagged DLI is associated with 2.16 fewer births per 1,000 women in their thirties. Among adolescent girls, greater digital life is also associated with fewer first births while the relationship is insignificant among women in their twenties and forties. The estimated negative relationship is also heterogeneous by marital status, occupational structure and education. The supplemental analyses further examine whether the relationship between digital life and fertility outcomes varies non-linearly. By including squared term of lagged DLI, I show that the results remain broadly consistent with the baseline findings.

This study makes three contributions to the growing literature on fertility in high-income countries. First, it extends existing research on the determinants of fertility by bringing digitalization as an additional determinant. Traditional economic models have emphasized women's employment opportunities, household resources, and the opportunity costs of childbearing. Recent research has increasingly examined whether technological changes, particularly remote work and broadband connectivity, can ease these constraints and encourage childbearing. The findings of this study complement this literature by bringing evidence from broader digital environment. This distinction is important because the ability to work remotely or digital accessibility alone may not adequately explain the trends in demographic trends or socioeconomic conditions. Second, this study contributes to the literature on dig-

ital measurement by introducing a composite index that captures distinct dimensions of digitalization which include remote work, digital leisure and digital accessibility. Third, the results also contribute to understand variation in fertility behavior across socioeconomic conditions and family circumstances. For example, the negative relationship is concentrated among women in 30-39 years if the spouse is in occupation with high remote work potential while the relationship is positive among women in 20-29 years if the spouse is not in such occupations.

The results also have implications for the ongoing discussions about declining fertility. Digital technologies can reduce commuting costs, facilitate access to information, and expand opportunities for flexible employment. However, the findings suggest that greater digitalization alone should not be assumed to improve fertility outcomes. The negative relationship among married women in their thirties, particularly for higher-order births, indicates that the potential benefits of digitalization may not be sufficient to offset other costs associated with having additional children. This highlights the need to consider how access to digital technologies interacts with actual working conditions and other related activities to understand their relationship with socioeconomic and demographic outcomes. Policies aimed at supporting work-family balance may therefore require more than expanding remote-work opportunities or digital infrastructure.

There are two limitations. First, the study shows the nature of association rather than the causal evidence. While the models include time-varying lagged digital life index to address reverse causality and include lagged local economic growth and fertility, this still may not rule out endogeneity concerns coming from other unobserved factors influencing the digitalization-fertility relationship. Second, birth outcomes are constructed from changes in children's presence in CPS household rosters, which may introduce measurement errors and cannot fully capture all fertility events. The relatively short observation window also limits the ability to distinguish delayed childbearing from permanent reductions in completed fertility.

Nevertheless, the findings suggest that the expansion of digital life is associated with lower birth incidence among women in their thirties, particularly for higher-order births, but that this relationship varies substantially across reproductive ages, education, and household occupational circumstances. As work, leisure, and social interactions continue to move online, understanding how these changes relate to family formation and childbearing will become increasingly important. Such evidence could help clarify the role of digitalization in broader demographic transformations occurring across high-income countries.

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A Additional Regression Results

A1 Digital Life and Any Birth

Table A1: Digital Life and Any Birth Across Reproductive Age Groups

	Any Birth			
	(1) Ages 15–19	(2) Ages 20–29	(3) Ages 30–39	(4) Ages 40–49
Lagged Digital Life Index	-0.000269	0.000981	-0.002168**	0.000353
	(0.000504)	(0.000992)	(0.000968)	(0.000483)
Lagged fertility rate	-0.000264	-0.000570	-0.000063	0.000227
	(0.000223)	(0.000375)	(0.000449)	(0.000232)
Age	0.000956***	-0.000831	0.000811	0.000011
	(0.000326)	(0.000620)	(0.000667)	(0.000370)
Lagged GDP growth	0.000087	0.000487**	0.000058	-0.000012
	(0.000070)	(0.000227)	(0.000261)	(0.000102)
Constant	-0.000806	0.057133**	-0.018932	-0.012960
	(0.015704)	(0.024188)	(0.031390)	(0.024245)
Observations	101,955	243,985	294,270	139,822
R^2	0.3259	0.3062	0.2806	0.3190
Adjusted R^2	0.0381	0.0035	-0.0082	0.0404
Within R^2	0.0001	0.0000	0.0000	0.0000
Individual fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Conception-month fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Sampling weights	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
State clusters	51	51	51	51

Notes: The dependent variable is a binary indicator for any birth. Each column reports a separate weighted linear probability model for the indicated age group. The Digital Life Index is standardized, so its coefficient represents the change in monthly birth probability associated with a one-standard-deviation increase in lagged digital life. All specifications include individual and conception-month fixed effects. Regressions use CPS panel weights (`panlwt`). Standard errors, clustered at the state level, are reported in parentheses. Singleton observations are excluded. Statistical significance: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

A2 Digital Life and First Birth

Table A2: Digital Life and First Birth Across Reproductive Age Groups

	First Birth			
	(1) Ages 15–19	(2) Ages 20–29	(3) Ages 30–39	(4) Ages 40–49
Lagged Digital Life Index	-0.000744*	0.000713	-0.001805	0.000234
	(0.000385)	(0.000892)	(0.001775)	(0.000330)
Lagged fertility rate	-0.000403*	-0.000649**	-0.001934***	-0.000188
	(0.000219)	(0.000320)	(0.000702)	(0.000209)
Age	0.000297	-0.000002	-0.001700	-0.001955***
	(0.000268)	(0.000593)	(0.001106)	(0.000711)
Lagged GDP growth	0.000029	0.000101	0.000115	0.000119
	(0.000067)	(0.000247)	(0.000290)	(0.000148)
Constant	0.018838	0.039724*	0.173271***	0.093248***
	(0.014682)	(0.020079)	(0.053264)	(0.026823)
Observations	100,268	176,907	97,634	35,400
R^2	0.3736	0.3985	0.3707	0.3795
Adjusted R^2	0.1064	0.1319	0.1017	0.1087
Within R^2	0.0001	0.0000	0.0002	0.0004
Individual fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Conception-month fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Sampling weights	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
State clusters	51	51	51	51

Notes: The dependent variable is a binary indicator for first birth. Each column reports a separate weighted linear probability model for the indicated age group. The Digital Life Index is standardized, so its coefficient represents the change in monthly first-birth probability associated with a one-standard-deviation increase in lagged digital life. All specifications include individual and conception-month fixed effects. Regressions use CPS panel weights (`panlwt`). Standard errors, clustered at the state level, are reported in parentheses. Singleton observations are excluded. Statistical significance: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

A3 Digital Life and Higher-Order Birth

Table A3: Digital Life and Higher-Order Birth Across Reproductive Age Groups

	Higher-Order Birth			
	(1) Ages 15–19	(2) Ages 20–29	(3) Ages 30–39	(4) Ages 40–49
Lagged Digital Life Index	0.001565	0.001648	-0.002071*	0.000409
	(0.003944)	(0.002449)	(0.001043)	(0.000613)
Lagged fertility rate	0.000968	0.000570	0.000581	0.000365
	(0.002404)	(0.000910)	(0.000535)	(0.000337)
Age	0.004170	-0.002373	0.001120	0.000404
	(0.006139)	(0.001969)	(0.000780)	(0.000444)
Lagged GDP growth	0.003168	0.000905	-0.000046	0.000002
	(0.004479)	(0.000645)	(0.000387)	(0.000138)
Constant	-0.140555	0.034393	-0.067579*	-0.037630
	(0.222400)	(0.076153)	(0.035043)	(0.030097)
Observations	1,579	66,017	195,441	103,925
R^2	0.3618	0.3005	0.2817	0.3192
Adjusted R^2	-0.0308	-0.0079	-0.0039	0.0418
Within R^2	0.0010	0.0001	0.0000	0.0000
Individual fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Conception-month fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Sampling weights	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
State clusters	50	51	51	51

Notes: The dependent variable is a binary indicator for higher-order birth. Each column reports a separate weighted linear probability model for the indicated age group. The Digital Life Index is standardized, so its coefficient represents the change in monthly higher-order birth probability associated with a one-standard-deviation increase in lagged digital life. All specifications include individual and conception-month fixed effects. Regressions use CPS panel weights (`panlwt`). Standard errors, clustered at the state level, are reported in parentheses. Singleton observations are excluded. The sample for ages 15–19 contains 1,579 observations and 50 state clusters. Statistical significance: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Table A4: Digital Life and Any Birth by Marital Status and Age

	Spouse present			**Spouse absent**			**Unmarried**		
	20–29	30–39	40–49	20–29	30–39	40–49	20–29	30–39	40–49
Lagged Digital Life Index	0.002813	-0.003796**	0.000028	-0.034042	-0.009688	-0.000724	-0.000074	-0.000012	0.000178
	(0.003470)	(0.001493)	(0.000695)	(0.023793)	(0.008538)	(0.001135)	(0.001078)	(0.001048)	(0.000819)
Lagged fertility rate	-0.002066	-0.000291	0.000363	0.012941	0.001164	-0.000627	-0.000052	0.000639	0.000474
	(0.001339)	(0.000607)	(0.000321)	(0.009371)	(0.002031)	(0.000745)	(0.000309)	(0.000552)	(0.000369)
Age	-0.004203	0.001364	0.000409	0.014774	0.001722	-0.002304	-0.000330	-0.000334	-0.000419
	(0.002507)	(0.001136)	(0.000539)	(0.008829)	(0.001641)	(0.002468)	(0.000604)	(0.000659)	(0.000314)
Lagged GDP growth	0.000822	0.000043	0.000091	0.003067	0.001588	-0.000235	0.000396*	-0.000121	-0.000276
	(0.000902)	(0.000378)	(0.000130)	(0.003311)	(0.002278)	(0.000283)	(0.000221)	(0.000237)	(0.000238)
Constant	0.243223***	-0.022609	-0.037887	-1.138845*	-0.128349	0.134976	0.012134	-0.023363	-0.008532
	(0.085054)	(0.045138)	(0.034778)	(0.585441)	(0.139008)	(0.143620)	(0.026221)	(0.045188)	(0.023297)
Observations	61,042	175,550	90,627	2,584	4,188	2,047	170,328	80,530	22,540
R^2	0.2975	0.2772	0.3271	0.3771	0.3162	0.3771	0.3211	0.3007	0.3141
Adjusted R^2	-0.0085	-0.0068	0.0571	0.0296	-0.0325	0.0257	0.0213	0.0027	0.0120
Within R^2	0.0002	0.0001	0.0000	0.0080	0.0008	0.0006	0.0000	0.0000	0.0001
State clusters	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
Individual fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Conception-month fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Sampling weights	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each column is a separate weighted linear probability model for the indicated marital-status and age subgroup. Lagged Digital Life Index is standardized. Coefficients are changes in monthly birth probability per one-standard-deviation increase in the index. All models include individual and conception-month fixed effects and control for lagged fertility, age, and lagged GDP growth. CPS panel weights (`panlwt`) are applied. State-clustered standard errors appear in parentheses; singleton observations are dropped. Stars indicate *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Table A5: Digital Life and First Birth by Marital Status and Age

	Spouse present			**Spouse absent**			**Unmarried**		
	20–29	30–39	40–49	20–29	30–39	40–49	20–29	30–39	40–49
Lagged Digital Life Index	0.002433	-0.004020	0.000479	0.000265	-0.006937	-0.004442	-0.000033	0.000363	0.000021
	(0.004300)	(0.004538)	(0.000775)	(0.003013)	(0.007890)	(0.004976)	(0.000660)	(0.000837)	(0.000056)
Lagged fertility rate	-0.003197	-0.004221**	-0.000399	0.000609	-0.001350	-0.000458	-0.000197	0.000025	0.000023
	(0.002011)	(0.001778)	(0.000504)	(0.000583)	(0.002808)	(0.002319)	(0.000205)	(0.000263)	(0.000036)
Age	-0.003510	-0.004083	-0.004076**	-0.003687	-0.000072	-0.005223	0.000612	-0.001114**	-0.000226
	(0.002575)	(0.002667)	(0.001665)	(0.002966)	(0.002398)	(0.005498)	(0.000587)	(0.000537)	(0.000240)
Lagged GDP growth	-0.000405	-0.000355	0.000348	-0.000289	0.001166	-0.000819	0.000110	0.000120	0.000014
	(0.001377)	(0.000667)	(0.000364)	(0.000565)	(0.001359)	(0.001161)	(0.000147)	(0.000194)	(0.000022)
Constant	0.290779**	0.393402***	0.194687***	0.059189	0.079808	0.251367	-0.002366	0.036450	0.008184
	(0.109242)	(0.118795)	(0.066188)	(0.092868)	(0.183238)	(0.276278)	(0.019449)	(0.030416)	(0.008989)
Observations	26,318	36,141	14,540	1,635	1,676	611	143,975	48,883	12,632
R^2	0.4043	0.3714	0.3785	0.5201	0.3818	0.4592	0.3862	0.3764	0.3169
Adjusted R^2	0.1281	0.1015	0.1054	0.2275	0.0166	0.0063	0.1138	0.1061	0.0144
Within R^2	0.0002	0.0006	0.0009	0.0004	0.0010	0.0010	0.0000	0.0001	0.0000
State clusters	51	51	51	51	51	45	51	51	51
Individual fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Conception-month fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Sampling weights	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each column is a separate weighted linear probability model for the indicated marital-status and age subgroup. Lagged Digital Life Index is standardized. Coefficients are changes in monthly birth probability per one-standard-deviation increase in the index. All models include individual and conception-month fixed effects and control for lagged fertility, age, and lagged GDP growth. CPS panel weights (`panlwt`) are applied. State-clustered standard errors appear in parentheses; singleton observations are dropped. Stars indicate *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Table A6: Digital Life and Higher-Order Birth by Marital Status and Age

	Spouse present			**Spouse absent**			**Unmarried**		
	20–29	30–39	40–49	20–29	30–39	40–49	20–29	30–39	40–49
Lagged Digital Life Index	0.003089	-0.003624**	-0.000083	-0.030902	-0.002942	—	0.001490	0.001348	0.000981
	(0.004004)	(0.001361)	(0.000813)	(0.029371)	(0.009155)	—	(0.004310)	(0.001641)	(0.000891)
Lagged fertility rate	-0.001479	0.000569	0.000573	0.008118	0.000344	—	0.002847*	0.001026	0.000356
	(0.001656)	(0.000653)	(0.000398)	(0.008976)	(0.002019)	—	(0.001474)	(0.001008)	(0.000407)
Age	-0.005170*	0.001549	0.001017*	0.037456	-0.001098	—	-0.003419	0.000078	-0.001314
	(0.002934)	(0.001187)	(0.000533)	(0.024669)	(0.003243)	—	(0.002971)	(0.001177)	(0.000975)
Lagged GDP growth	0.001653	-0.000053	0.000080	0.000378	-0.001658	—	0.000231	-0.000126	-0.000226
	(0.001178)	(0.000504)	(0.000168)	(0.004722)	(0.001617)	—	(0.001220)	(0.000500)	(0.000171)
Constant	0.232059*	-0.080765	-0.075801**	-1.457124*	0.027226	—	-0.075908	-0.059365	0.035710
	(0.130284)	(0.048138)	(0.037395)	(0.796883)	(0.195884)	—	(0.107538)	(0.078088)	(0.029719)
Observations	34,279	138,732	75,817	923	2,487	1,420	25,806	31,336	9,809
R^2	0.2936	0.2786	0.3304	0.4111	0.3433	—	0.3280	0.3024	0.3192
Adjusted R^2	-0.0153	-0.0042	0.0625	0.0217	-0.0016	—	0.0211	0.0039	0.0044
Within R^2	0.0003	0.0001	0.0001	0.0112	0.0002	—	0.0002	0.0001	0.0002
State clusters	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
Individual fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Conception-month fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Sampling weights	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each column is a separate weighted linear probability model for the indicated marital-status and age subgroup. Lagged Digital Life Index is standardized. Coefficients are changes in monthly birth probability per one-standard-deviation increase in the index. All models include individual and conception-month fixed effects and control for lagged fertility, age, and lagged GDP growth. CPS panel weights (`panlwt`) are applied. State-clustered standard errors appear in parentheses; singleton observations are dropped. Stars indicate *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$. — indicates coefficients omitted by Stata (the spouse-absent, ages 40–49 subgroup), not a zero estimate.

Table A7: Digital Life and Any Birth by Remote-Work Potential and Age

	High Remote work potential			**High Face-to-face work potential**		
	20–29	30–39	40–49	20–29	30–39	40–49
Lagged Digital Life Index	0.002149	-0.002220**	0.000750	0.000946	-0.001579	-0.000014
	(0.001450)	(0.001021)	(0.000776)	(0.001546)	(0.002432)	(0.000331)
Lagged fertility rate	-0.000533	0.000506	0.000117	-0.001305**	-0.000843	0.000244
	(0.000592)	(0.000581)	(0.000318)	(0.000628)	(0.001008)	(0.000339)
Age	-0.000971	0.001483	0.000246	-0.001905	0.000577	-0.000222
	(0.000880)	(0.000889)	(0.000518)	(0.001268)	(0.001148)	(0.000291)
Lagged GDP growth	0.000682**	0.000257	0.000004	0.000257	-0.000013	-0.000128
	(0.000300)	(0.000420)	(0.000106)	(0.000424)	(0.000757)	(0.000195)
Constant	0.058541	-0.075765*	-0.016347	0.125727**	0.034135	-0.003998
	(0.038992)	(0.040335)	(0.033872)	(0.052017)	(0.075371)	(0.020181)
Observations	153,583	206,111	97,719	80,393	80,863	38,853
R^2	0.3260	0.2902	0.3324	0.3416	0.3162	0.3165
Adjusted R^2	0.0093	-0.0100	0.0461	0.0135	0.0031	0.0024
Within R^2	0.0001	0.0001	0.0000	0.0001	0.0000	0.0000
State clusters	51	51	51	51	51	51
Individual fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Conception-month fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Sampling weights	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each column reports a separate weighted linear probability regression for the indicated age group and occupational category. High Remote work potential is defined as `remote_dummy=1`; the comparison group is `remote_dummy=0`. The latter denotes High Face-to-face work potential, not necessarily exclusively face-to-face work. The dependent variable is a binary indicator of any birth. The Digital Life Index is standardized; coefficient estimates refer to changes in monthly birth probability associated with a one-standard-deviation increase in lagged DLI. All models absorb individual and conception-month fixed effects and use CPS panel weights (`panlwt`). Standard errors clustered by state are in parentheses; singleton observations are excluded. Significance: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Table A8: Digital Life and First Birth by Remote-Work Potential and Age

	High Remote work potential			**High Face-to-face work potential**		
	20–29	30–39	40–49	20–29	30–39	40–49
Lagged Digital Life Index	0.001641	-0.001720	0.000380	0.000952	0.001840	0.000260
	(0.001378)	(0.001824)	(0.000481)	(0.001334)	(0.002513)	(0.000240)
Lagged fertility rate	-0.000224	-0.002581***	-0.000294	-0.000938*	0.000941	-0.000009
	(0.000458)	(0.000753)	(0.000312)	(0.000546)	(0.000959)	(0.000053)
Age	-0.000580	-0.001684	-0.001991**	0.000590	-0.002610	-0.000342
	(0.000871)	(0.001249)	(0.000756)	(0.000773)	(0.001563)	(0.000343)
Lagged GDP growth	0.000335	0.000887*	0.000047	-0.000381	-0.001781***	-0.000037
	(0.000296)	(0.000477)	(0.000210)	(0.000503)	(0.000598)	(0.000039)
Constant	0.028168	0.207559***	0.101335***	0.043533	0.041982	0.015107
	(0.029630)	(0.057776)	(0.033064)	(0.035902)	(0.080347)	(0.013765)
Observations	109,289	68,215	25,303	60,299	26,953	9,220
R^2	0.4064	0.3754	0.3846	0.4111	0.3912	0.3574
Adjusted R^2	0.1229	0.0962	0.1043	0.1147	0.0976	0.0408
Within R^2	0.0001	0.0005	0.0003	0.0001	0.0005	0.0000
State clusters	51	51	51	51	51	51
Individual fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Conception-month fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Sampling weights	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each column reports a separate weighted linear probability regression for the indicated age group and occupational category. High Remote work potential is defined as `remote_dummy=1`; the comparison group is `remote_dummy=0`. The latter denotes High Face-to-face work potential, not necessarily exclusively face-to-face work. The dependent variable is a binary indicator of first birth. The Digital Life Index is standardized; coefficient estimates refer to changes in monthly birth probability associated with a one-standard-deviation increase in lagged DLI. All models absorb individual and conception-month fixed effects and use CPS panel weights (`panlwt`). Standard errors clustered by state are in parentheses; singleton observations are excluded. Significance: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Table A9: Digital Life and Higher-Order Birth by Remote-Work Potential and Age

	High Remote work potential			**High Face-to-face work potential**		
	20–29	30–39	40–49	20–29	30–39	40–49
Lagged Digital Life Index	0.003156	-0.001927	0.000671	0.002391	-0.002332	0.000013
	(0.003936)	(0.001254)	(0.001032)	(0.003540)	(0.002884)	(0.000457)
Lagged fertility rate	-0.000408	0.001427**	0.000259	-0.001678	-0.001314	0.000333
	(0.001441)	(0.000654)	(0.000483)	(0.001567)	(0.001342)	(0.000447)
Age	-0.001603	0.002556**	0.000533	-0.006937*	-0.000413	0.000067
	(0.002425)	(0.001245)	(0.000679)	(0.004083)	(0.001675)	(0.000347)
Lagged GDP growth	0.000471	-0.000030	0.000013	0.001375	0.000014	-0.000170
	(0.000791)	(0.000591)	(0.000160)	(0.001368)	(0.000946)	(0.000252)
Constant	0.075734	-0.166994***	-0.036778	0.281860*	0.096077	-0.021223
	(0.115399)	(0.052571)	(0.044007)	(0.159223)	(0.094361)	(0.033792)
Observations	43,568	137,024	72,074	19,724	53,550	29,465
R^2	0.3154	0.2911	0.3364	0.3581	0.3181	0.3141
Adjusted R^2	-0.0078	-0.0063	0.0524	0.0317	0.0077	-0.0001
Within R^2	0.0000	0.0001	0.0000	0.0006	0.0001	0.0000
State clusters	51	51	51	51	51	51
Individual fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Conception-month fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Sampling weights	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each column reports a separate weighted linear probability regression for the indicated age group and occupational category. High Remote work potential is defined as `remote_dummy=1`; the comparison group is `remote_dummy=0`. The latter denotes High Face-to-face work potential, not necessarily exclusively face-to-face work. The dependent variable is a binary indicator of higher-order birth. The Digital Life Index is standardized; coefficient estimates refer to changes in monthly birth probability associated with a one-standard-deviation increase in lagged DLI. All models absorb individual and conception-month fixed effects and use CPS panel weights (`panlwt`). Standard errors clustered by state are in parentheses; singleton observations are excluded. Significance: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Table A10: Digital Life and Any Birth by Husband's Remote-Work Potential and Age

	High Remote-Work Potential			**High Face-to-Face Potential**		
	20–29	30–39	40–49	20–29	30–39	40–49
Lagged Digital Life Index	0.000144	-0.002696**	0.000427	0.010149**	-0.001917	0.000246
	(0.000960)	(0.001046)	(0.000695)	(0.003832)	(0.002006)	(0.001010)
Lagged fertility rate	-0.000239	-0.000202	-0.000029	-0.001980	0.000969	0.001125*
	(0.000358)	(0.000520)	(0.000297)	(0.001387)	(0.001143)	(0.000633)
Age	0.000355	0.001052	-0.000462	-0.007354***	0.001094	0.001323
	(0.000680)	(0.000722)	(0.000320)	(0.002515)	(0.001736)	(0.001585)
Lagged GDP growth	0.000495*	0.000258	0.000051	0.000109	-0.000464	-0.000163
	(0.000248)	(0.000334)	(0.000110)	(0.001071)	(0.000614)	(0.000325)
Constant	0.007261	-0.019880	0.021598	0.316871***	-0.087628	-0.120118
	(0.024588)	(0.035117)	(0.025611)	(0.101995)	(0.079298)	(0.088499)
Observations	197,521	212,514	100,941	43,758	77,559	36,904
R^2	0.3171	0.2886	0.3148	0.3190	0.3040	0.3373
Adjusted R^2	0.0131	-0.0093	0.0238	-0.0019	0.0001	0.0402
Within R^2	0.0000	0.0001	0.0000	0.0005	0.0001	0.0002
State clusters	51	51	51	51	51	51
Individual fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Conception-month fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Sampling weights	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each column reports a separate weighted linear probability model for women in the indicated age group, classified by their husband's remote-work potential. High remote-work potential denotes `husband_remote==1`, while high face-to-face work potential denotes `husband_remote==0`. The standardized lagged Digital Life Index coefficient measures the association with monthly birth probability for a one-standard-deviation increase in the index. Models adjust for lagged fertility, age, and lagged GDP growth and absorb individual and conception-month fixed effects. CPS panel weights (`panlwt`) are used. State-clustered standard errors are in parentheses; singleton observations are excluded. Significance: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Table A11: Digital Life and First Birth by Husband's Remote-Work Potential and Age

	High Remote-Work Potential			**High Face-to-Face Potential**		
	20–29	30–39	40–49	20–29	30–39	40–49
Lagged Digital Life Index	0.000260	-0.002693	0.000070	0.009166**	0.001640	0.001163
	(0.000801)	(0.001815)	(0.000295)	(0.003733)	(0.005096)	(0.002056)
Lagged fertility rate	-0.000068	-0.001404*	-0.000249	-0.004641*	-0.004221*	-0.000201
	(0.000299)	(0.000822)	(0.000265)	(0.002372)	(0.002392)	(0.000670)
Age	0.000200	-0.002059**	-0.001527**	-0.001840	0.002251	-0.004184
	(0.000566)	(0.000962)	(0.000627)	(0.003575)	(0.004028)	(0.003550)
Lagged GDP growth	0.000081	0.000895***	0.000071	0.000558	-0.005021***	0.000402
	(0.000234)	(0.000315)	(0.000179)	(0.001246)	(0.001104)	(0.000657)
Constant	0.000430	0.151762**	0.078891***	0.325933**	0.191329	0.187314
	(0.021219)	(0.056573)	(0.027962)	(0.140722)	(0.213732)	(0.168079)
Observations	156,796	81,278	28,339	18,802	15,246	6,608
R^2	0.3957	0.3783	0.3858	0.4223	0.3698	0.3743
Adjusted R^2	0.1260	0.1073	0.1125	0.1321	0.0673	0.0610
Within R^2	0.0000	0.0004	0.0003	0.0006	0.0018	0.0011
State clusters	51	51	51	51	51	51
Individual fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Conception-month fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Sampling weights	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each column reports a separate weighted linear probability model for women in the indicated age group, classified by their husband's remote-work potential. High remote-work potential denotes `husband_remote==1`, while high face-to-face work potential denotes `husband_remote==0`. The standardized lagged Digital Life Index coefficient measures the association with monthly birth probability for a one-standard-deviation increase in the index. Models adjust for lagged fertility, age, and lagged GDP growth and absorb individual and conception-month fixed effects. CPS panel weights (`panlwt`) are used. State-clustered standard errors are in parentheses; singleton observations are excluded. Significance: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Table A12: Digital Life and Higher-Order Birth by Husband's Remote-Work Potential and Age

	High Remote-Work Potential			**High Face-to-Face Potential**		
	20–29	30–39	40–49	20–29	30–39	40–49
Lagged Digital Life Index	0.000807	-0.002259*	0.000497	0.008977	-0.001802	0.000426
	(0.002832)	(0.001209)	(0.000972)	(0.005903)	(0.002427)	(0.000909)
Lagged fertility rate	0.000378	0.000300	-0.000051	0.001147	0.001641	0.001722**
	(0.001370)	(0.000712)	(0.000402)	(0.001873)	(0.001102)	(0.000821)
Age	0.000736	0.002098*	-0.000198	-0.008225**	-0.000125	0.001903
	(0.003078)	(0.001131)	(0.000418)	(0.003333)	(0.001362)	(0.001397)
Lagged GDP growth	0.000968	-0.000122	0.000040	0.000334	0.000250	-0.000047
	(0.000857)	(0.000468)	(0.000156)	(0.001373)	(0.000660)	(0.000332)
Constant	-0.036396	-0.084846*	0.011871	0.155924	-0.088131	-0.180227**
	(0.104457)	(0.044315)	(0.032222)	(0.156693)	(0.064054)	(0.087920)
Observations	39,934	130,353	72,243	24,654	61,986	30,143
R^2	0.3145	0.2899	0.3104	0.3193	0.3102	0.3524
Adjusted R^2	-0.0047	-0.0069	0.0171	0.0010	0.0111	0.0637
Within R^2	0.0000	0.0001	0.0000	0.0005	0.0001	0.0006
State clusters	51	51	51	51	51	51
Individual fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Conception-month fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Sampling weights	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each column reports a separate weighted linear probability model for women in the indicated age group, classified by their husband's remote-work potential. High remote-work potential denotes `husband_remote==1`, while high face-to-face work potential denotes `husband_remote==0`. The standardized lagged Digital Life Index coefficient measures the association with monthly birth probability for a one-standard-deviation increase in the index. Models adjust for lagged fertility, age, and lagged GDP growth and absorb individual and conception-month fixed effects. CPS panel weights (`panlwt`) are used. State-clustered standard errors are in parentheses; singleton observations are excluded. Significance: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Table A13: Digital Life and Any Birth by Postsecondary Education and Age

	Bachelor's degree or higher			**Postsecondary below bachelor's**		
	20–29	30–39	40–49	20–29	30–39	40–49
Lagged Digital Life Index	0.002311	-0.001127	0.001202	-0.000435	-0.004960***	-0.000594
	(0.002024)	(0.001401)	(0.000828)	(0.001594)	(0.001590)	(0.000670)
Lagged fertility rate	-0.000866	-0.000474	0.000453	-0.001406**	0.000458	0.000185
	(0.000629)	(0.000918)	(0.000398)	(0.000630)	(0.000715)	(0.000342)
Age	0.000764	0.002204	0.000342	-0.001996	-0.000220	-0.001004
	(0.001481)	(0.001409)	(0.000438)	(0.001236)	(0.001132)	(0.000662)
Lagged GDP growth	0.000521	0.000589	0.000104	0.000389	-0.000446	0.000257
	(0.000388)	(0.000478)	(0.000125)	(0.000409)	(0.000432)	(0.000174)
Constant	0.032659	-0.043497	-0.040432	0.133204***	-0.012984	0.031032
	(0.046136)	(0.059696)	(0.035070)	(0.047727)	(0.054252)	(0.040308)
Observations	76,985	133,578	61,885	90,047	77,481	35,718
R^2	0.3047	0.2782	0.3017	0.3120	0.2939	0.3696
Adjusted R^2	-0.0073	-0.0125	0.0163	0.0022	-0.0004	0.0976
Within R^2	0.0001	0.0001	0.0001	0.0001	0.0002	0.0002
State clusters	51	51	51	51	51	51
Individual fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Conception-month fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Sampling weights	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each column is a separate weighted linear probability model for the indicated education and age subgroup. The dependent variable is any birth. The education groups are defined by `college_grad`: 1 denotes a bachelor's degree or higher and 0 denotes postsecondary education below a bachelor's degree, as coded in the supplied Stata output. The Digital Life Index is standardized; coefficients are changes in monthly birth probability associated with a one-standard-deviation higher lagged index. All specifications control for lagged fertility, age, and lagged GDP growth and absorb individual and conception-month fixed effects. CPS panel weights (`panlwt`) are applied. State-clustered standard errors appear in parentheses. Singleton observations are dropped. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Table A14: Digital Life and First Birth by Postsecondary Education and Age

	Bachelor's degree or higher			**Postsecondary below bachelor's**		
	20–29	30–39	40–49	20–29	30–39	40–49
Lagged Digital Life Index	0.002631*	-0.000683	0.000139	-0.001327	-0.004898**	0.000062
	(0.001488)	(0.002912)	(0.000525)	(0.002050)	(0.002188)	(0.000260)
Lagged fertility rate	-0.001059*	-0.003092**	-0.000425	-0.000672	-0.000462	0.000150
	(0.000537)	(0.001189)	(0.000470)	(0.000494)	(0.001321)	(0.000176)
Age	-0.000696	-0.002063	-0.002279*	-0.000425	-0.002553	-0.001067*
	(0.000609)	(0.001883)	(0.001192)	(0.000916)	(0.001699)	(0.000602)
Lagged GDP growth	-0.000192	0.000602	0.000113	0.000502	0.000039	-0.000041
	(0.000394)	(0.000502)	(0.000296)	(0.000408)	(0.000654)	(0.000067)
Constant	0.081500**	0.250440***	0.120427**	0.049593	0.117338	0.036802
	(0.032160)	(0.090197)	(0.046390)	(0.037753)	(0.107123)	(0.023065)
Observations	65,306	53,285	15,527	67,028	20,980	8,765
R^2	0.4003	0.3687	0.3945	0.4024	0.3790	0.3893
Adjusted R^2	0.1271	0.0967	0.1292	0.1288	0.1007	0.1028
Within R^2	0.0001	0.0004	0.0005	0.0001	0.0003	0.0001
State clusters	51	51	51	51	51	51
Individual fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Conception-month fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Sampling weights	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each column is a separate weighted linear probability model for the indicated education and age subgroup. The dependent variable is first birth. The education groups are defined by `college_grad`: 1 denotes a bachelor's degree or higher and 0 denotes postsecondary education below a bachelor's degree, as coded in the supplied Stata output. The Digital Life Index is standardized; coefficients are changes in monthly birth probability associated with a one-standard-deviation higher lagged index. All specifications control for lagged fertility, age, and lagged GDP growth and absorb individual and conception-month fixed effects. CPS panel weights (`panlwt`) are applied. State-clustered standard errors appear in parentheses. Singleton observations are dropped. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

Table A15: Digital Life and Higher-Order Birth by Postsecondary Education and Age

	Bachelor's degree or higher			**Postsecondary below bachelor's**		
	20–29	30–39	40–49	20–29	30–39	40–49
Lagged Digital Life Index	-0.006189	-0.001008	0.001409	-0.000494	-0.004420***	-0.000760
	(0.005150)	(0.001764)	(0.001057)	(0.004406)	(0.001562)	(0.000893)
Lagged fertility rate	-0.000240	0.001132	0.000671	-0.000156	-0.000215	0.000218
	(0.003259)	(0.001282)	(0.000582)	(0.001798)	(0.000965)	(0.000447)
Age	0.008729	0.003530*	0.000879**	-0.003699	-0.000065	-0.001108
	(0.007512)	(0.001859)	(0.000378)	(0.003747)	(0.001141)	(0.000886)
Lagged GDP growth	0.000996	0.000673	0.000142	0.000859	-0.001031	0.000331
	(0.001392)	(0.000705)	(0.000164)	(0.001386)	(0.000718)	(0.000229)
Constant	-0.216763	-0.185152**	-0.075915*	0.111236	0.023042	0.033087
	(0.303172)	(0.077479)	(0.039585)	(0.164144)	(0.068351)	(0.054669)
Observations	11,424	79,831	46,191	22,696	56,189	26,825
R^2	0.3072	0.2785	0.2889	0.3047	0.2958	0.3894
Adjusted R^2	-0.0108	-0.0074	0.0007	-0.0091	0.0048	0.1259
Within R^2	0.0006	0.0001	0.0002	0.0001	0.0002	0.0002
State clusters	51	51	51	51	51	51
Individual fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Conception-month fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Sampling weights	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Each column is a separate weighted linear probability model for the indicated education and age subgroup. The dependent variable is higher-order birth. The education groups are defined by `college_grad`: 1 denotes a bachelor's degree or higher and 0 denotes postsecondary education below a bachelor's degree, as coded in the supplied Stata output. The Digital Life Index is standardized; coefficients are changes in monthly birth probability associated with a one-standard-deviation higher lagged index. All specifications control for lagged fertility, age, and lagged GDP growth and absorb individual and conception-month fixed effects. CPS panel weights (`panlwt`) are applied. State-clustered standard errors appear in parentheses. Singleton observations are dropped. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$.

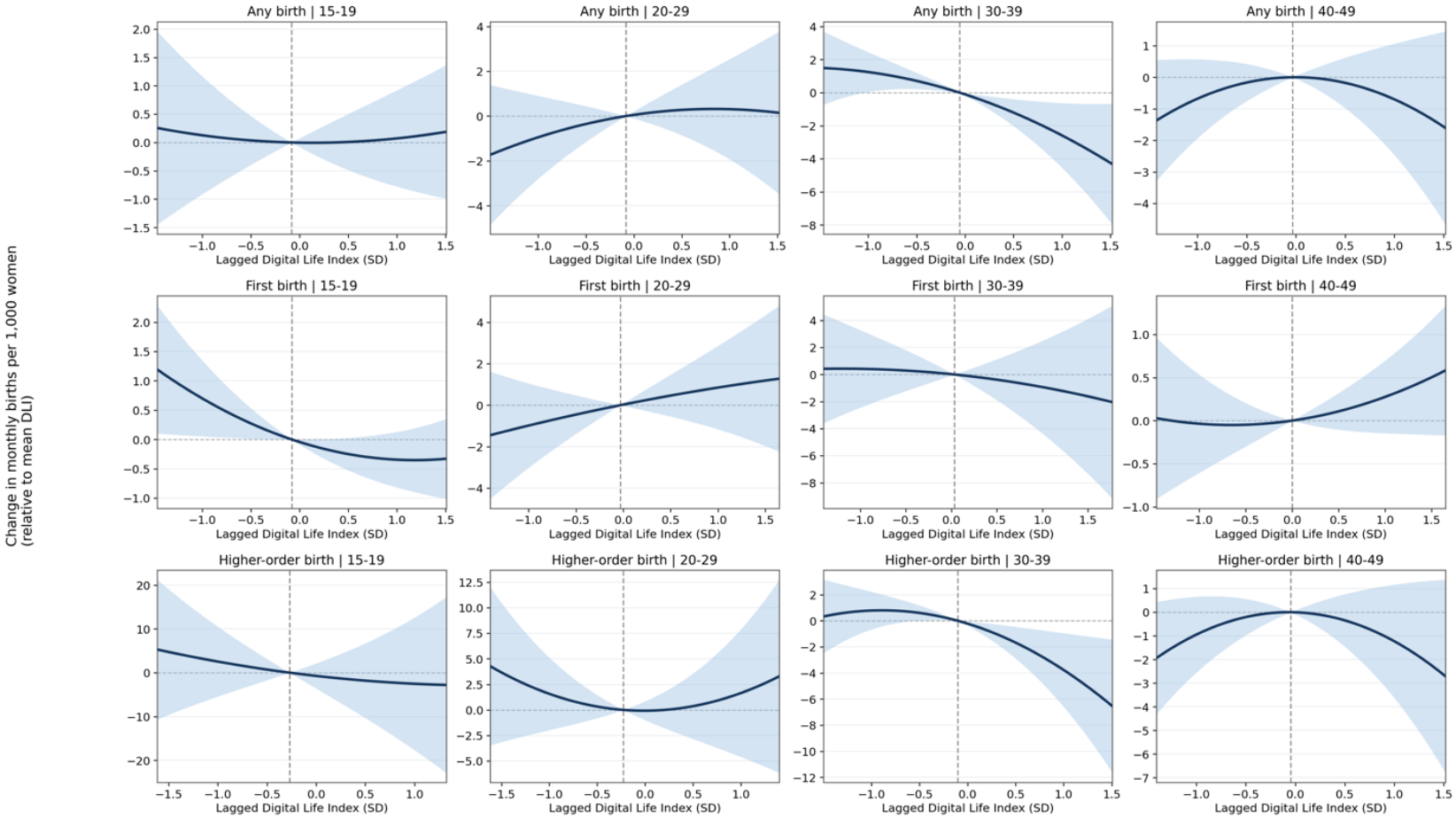


Figure 8: Fitted Plots of the Nonlinear Relationship Between Digital Life and Birth Outcomes. The figure reports predicted births and 95% confidence intervals for any birth, first birth, and higher-order birth among women aged 15–19, 20–29, 30–39, and 40–49 years. All specifications control for age, lagged state-level general fertility rates, and real GDP growth, and include individual and conception-month fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the state level.